LFH Case No. 132

Bennett Valley Cal.[1]
Sept. 8, 1876

Dear True Friend Ettie,

Perhaps you know how glad I was to get your letter; but I scarcely think you do indeed words fail me when I would portran [portray] to you my great joy. for believe me I had not a word from this. until your epistle was handed me. except a few words in John's letter from Libbie.

I suppose you do think I'm not able to write, but let me put a stop to that train of thought immediately. My spine is nearly well I have not had a head ache for a week apetite more than I could wish for. I wish you could see the platter of fruit that is nearly always on the stand. you would not wonder that I could eat.

I would like to step in and wake you up this evening with an account in full of my trip. would'nt I make you laugh? Telling of the many adventures and hairbredth escapes; Of the joys and sorrows necessary as well as unavoided to make –complete– a journey so long. I wish you could know just what a fine trip it is to come out here; and how wonderfully grand the scenery is. I would enjoy looking as long as my poor weak head would allow and then cry because I could no longer endure the varied changes through which we were passing.

In Tame Wisconsin you can not, (no not even with the vivid description that I might give you) realize how rugged, ragged, and cragged are the bold old Rocky Mountains; Sometimes I could scarcely bear to look at the masses of rocks towering hundreds of feet above us, and overreaching the track where if they had given way and come upon us we would have been; but as a straw beneath our locomotive.

Oh! My Dear Ettie are not the works of God beyond our comprehension? Was it to bring out the powers of man that the Rocky Mountains were formed.

You can not understand and how perfectly wonderful the building of the road we traveled on coming here seems to me. The deep cuts and tunnels that we passed through, and the bridges we passed over I of course was very nervous part of the time; and I must tell you Cousin

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1 1See: *1879 5 3 Letter - Emma J. Thayer To Juliette A. E. Flagler, 186*. See also: *1876 9 8 Letter -- Emma J. Thayer To Juliette A. E. Flagler, 132*; *1879 5 3 Letter - Emma J. Thayer To Juliette A. E. Flagler, 186; 1879 10 1 Letter - Emma J. Thayer To Juliette A .E. Flagler, 197*.

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John was just as kind as a brother could be. We had thunderstorms every night until we reached the mountains, and I think I never suffered more in my life; I kept nearly every one in the car awake, but there was another woman who was just about as bad as I, which was quite consoling.

We had several delays one that I so will remember was at North Plat– a place where the U.S.S [oldiers?] are stationed; and I'm sorry; but we have to admit that they are some of them unfit to be killed.

Robbie has just cut a mellon ; but I believe I do not care for any tonight. I shall not try to teach yet but I sometimes wish that I could train some of the Rock County urchins this winter; just see what a screamer this pen is; you see I've been writing so fast that it tries to talk; and thereby I'm reminded of the Puritan Maiden Prisilla is this spelled right, and the pen of John Alden.

I wanted to tell you about the Sierra Nevada mountains for they were so very beautiful, and of the pleasant people that I became acquainted with during the trip. I must tell you that we met at Omaha (well I do not know as that is spelled just right) some people returning from Centenial. They were so good and Ettie they liked me. I'm going to visit them soon; for they tell John if he does not soon bring me to Petaluma they will come after me. You seem to think that I'm having conquests out here but you are sadly mistaken for did I not pledge you my sacred honor that Cal should know me as a sober dignified girl too good to exist. if I did not make you that pledge it was from fear that I might be tempted to break it; and then you see my glory would be spoiled; but if I dont find a better field for conquesting than I have yet seen I think it will be some time before I care to enter in to any serious flirtations. Oh dear I do not care for the opposite sex as I used to. I know they are nice; but the're naughty I will finish this letter tomorrow for I can not go to church I am real tired tonight but will feel rested in the morning which is better than I could say of the East. Love and kisses to you and your mother.

P. d. Dear Ettie I must tell you how much I weigh you will scarcely credit the story when I tell you my weight was 125' lbs, when I arrived. Today it is 133 lbs. do I need medicine? I will post the letter you spoke of any time you send it. I am sorry that you imagine one trying to get sympathy. I will not do that, for you know it is against my principles to do that. Know really and surely dear Ettie I am not very particularly in favor of the Old wilderness and batchelors that I find here. I do not expect that I shall change my name just yet. Oh dear! I would like to step

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in and shake you good today you see I would be able to do that now. I tell you it is perfectly wonderful.

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I can not write any more this time but will do better next. Auntie is smoking and Bell has just returned from a visit to one of the neighbors. We are intending to go to the Coast in a few weeks , and John says that I must go to the red woods next week and camp out two or three nights; but I do not think I will try that just yet. Now Ettie if you see any of the people from home tell them a letter will come good any time I am quite happy. I do not like the seclusion that I have here, only I'd like to see some of my dear good friends in Old Wis. for I believe I have some there although as you are aware it was rather hard to tell just whether they were all true who pretended to be. I will speak more of the last days I spend in my old home next time for you know how unhappy I was when you were there.

P.S. Love and Kisses to you and Mother Flagler.

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LFH Case No. 132. 8 September 1876 Letter Emma J. Thayer, Petaluma, Sonoma Co., Bennett Valley, California to Juliette A. E. Flagler, Milton, Old Town, Rock Co. Wisconsin. Data: no Env.; 5 x 8? in; embossed?; no letterhead; no watermark; postscripts all around the letter; Wotim (Emma writes literally in every part of the letter she can: top, bottom, and side margins; over text; between lines, in circular pattern, etc.); blue-lined paper; 1 letter sheet; cursive; black ink; cotton-fibre; doc. cond. good; legibility poor; 1 date, 1 author; formal heading, per. formal greeting, complimentary close & no sig. line; written Friday morning. This letter is one of eight letters she wrote to Juliette A. E. Flagler.[2]

The letter depicts a transcontinental railroad trip from Milton, Wisconsin, to Bennett Valley, California. The letter reveals a very close bond and is filled with emotional energy depicting and describing the journey across America of Emma J. Thayer in 1876. The letter begins with Emma thanking Juliette ('Ettie') for her letter: "for believe me I had not a word from this. until your epistle was handed me. except a few words in John's letter from Libbie." In the next paragraph Ettie's friend gives us some idea for her move to California, stating that "my spine is nearly well" and that her appetite had returned, "I wish you could see the platter of fruit that is nearly always on the stand. you would not wonder that I could eat." In the third paragraph Emma begins the principal theme of her autograph, her 1876 transcontinental railroad journey from the Midwest to California. Her depiction of her journey is illuminating and filled with emotion. As she begins her narrative, "I would like to step in and wake you up this evening with an account in full of my trip. would'nt I make you laugh? Telling of the many adventures and hairbredth escapes; Of the joys and sorrows necessary as well as unavoided to make –complete– a journey so long." On line 20 she tells Ettie, "I wish you could know just what a fine trip it is to come out here; and how wonderfully grand the scenery is. I would enjoy looking as long as my poor weak head would allow and then cry because I could no longer endure the varied changes through which we were passing." She then attempts to tell Ettie how "rugged, ragged and cragged" the Rocky Mountains are, knowing how difficult it would be for a flatlander from "Tame Wisconsin" to realize thus: "Sometimes I could scarcely bear to look at the masses of rocks towering hundreds of feet above us, and overreaching the track where if they had given way and come upon us we would have been; but as a straw beneath our locomotive." Depicting the works of God beyond human comprehension, she asks "Was it to bring out the powers of man that the Rocky Mountains were formed?" She then mentions the "deep cuts and tunnels" they passed through, the bridges they passed over, and the nightly thunderstorms they experienced until they came to the Rocky Mountains. As she relates, "I never suffered more in my life; I kept nearly every one in the car awake, but there was another woman who was just about as bad as I, which was quite consoling." On line 43 she mentions the many train delays they experienced including one at Fort Platte, where she describes some of the Fort's soldiers "unfit to be killed." In her next paragraph Emma mentions that she won't teach as yet, even though she would like to teach some of the "Rock County urchins this winter." Then, in the ninth paragraph, she tells Ettie of some "pleasant people" she met in Omaha and their desire to see her in Petaluma, California, and then discusses her relationships with California men "You seem to think that I'm having

1 2See: *1879 5 3 Letter Emma J. Thayer to Juliette A. E. Flagler* and *1879 10 1 Letter Emma J. Thayer to Juliette A. E. Flagler, 197*.

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LFH Case No. 132. conquests out here but you are sadly mistaken for did I not pledge you my sacred honor that Cal should know me as a sober dignified girl too good to exist. if I did not make you that pledge it was from fear that I might be tempted to break it; and then you see my glory would be spoiled; but if I dont find a better field for conquesting than I have yet seen I think it will be some time you

see my glory would be spoiled; but if I dont find a better field for conquesting than I have yet seen I think it will be some time before I care to enter in to any serious flirtations." Similarly, "Oh dear I do not care for the opposite sex as I used to. I know they are nice; but the're naughty I will finish this letter tomorrow for I can not go to church I am real tired tonight." In the 10th paragraph Emma returns to her health telling Ettie she has gained eight pounds since arriving in California and then returns to the issue of men: "Know [?] really and surely dear Ettie I am not very particularly in favor of the Old wilderness and batchelors that I find here. I do not expect that I shall change my name just yet." In her final paragraph she tells Ettie that "John" wants her to go to the coast in a few weeks, and that she should plan on camping out in "the red woods"; that she would like more letters from home; that she feels somewhat secluded at times; and that she will write another letter on "the last days I spend in my old home next time for you know how unhappy I was when you were there." An extraordinary letter that deserves more research. Note: In researching the Thayer Family genealogy I came across a reference to Emma Jane Thayer in the 1880 U.S. Census for Bolinas, Marin Co., California. In the 1880 census report Emma's birth is "about 1853" in Wisconsin and her mother and father's birthplace is Maine" which correlates with the 1860 & 1870 U.S. Census for Janesville, Rock Co., Wis. In the 1880 U.S. Census for Bolinas, Marin Co., her occupation is listed as "School teacher." Both the Flagler and Thayer families appear on the same page in the 1860 and 1870 census reports for Janesville, Emma being 18 and Juliette 16. Similarly, in the Wisconsin Marriage records 1820-2004, Emma Jane Thayer married Josiah Robert Morrow on 15 Jan. 1881 in Janesville, Wisconsin. See: Emma J. Thayer wrote eight letters to Juliette A. E. Flagler: *1872 4 9 Letr. Emma Thayer to Juliaette A.E. Flagler, 061*; *1873 12 3 Letr. Emma Thayer To Juliaette A.E. Flagler, 62*; *1874 9 16 Letter - 'E' Emma Thayer To Juliaette A. E. Flagler, 078*; *1875 2 22 Letr. Emma J. Thayer 'E.J.F.' to Juliaette A.E. Flagler, 095*; *1875 3 14 Letr. 'E' Emma Thayer To Juliaette A.E. Flagler, 099*; and *1874 9 20 - Letter Emma Thayer To Juliette A. E. Flagler, 536*; *1876 9 8 Letter Emma J. Thayer To Juliette A. E. Flagler, 132*; and *1879 5 3 Letter - Emma J. Thayer To Juliette A. E. Flagler, 186*.

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